Official Community Plan

Phase 3

Engagement Summary
August 2025

CITY OF SURREY

Where We Are

Introduction

The Official Community Plan (OCP) is one of Surrey's most important documents. It sets a long-term vision for the city and guides how we grow and develop.

We started updating the plan in 2023. In the first two phases, we explored what residents love about Surrey and what they hope for its future. Through this process, we developed a draft vision, a shared set of values, and clear priorities to guide the plan.

What We Did

Phase 3: Developing

Engagement for Phase 3 began in March 2025 and focused on key policy directions that will help guide the growth of the City. Phase 3 engagement provided an opportunity for the public to give feedback on the priority directions. Engagement in Phase 3 included a community survey, in-person OCPPizza Parties, pop-up at a secondary school and workshops with 4 seldom heard communities.

By The Numbers...

There are approximately 610,000 residents within Surrey. Here's a breakdown of people that were engaged or informed in the Phase 3.

Approximately,

2,760+ Engaged Residents

An engaged resident is defined as an individual or group that has contributed to the project website, attended a pop-up event, connected through phone or email, completed the survey or attended an OCP event.

Residents were engaged through:

- **2,467** Surveys Completed & Questions Asked
- **200+** Event Attendees
- **100+** Website Contributions, Emails & Phone Calls

Approximately,

152,650+ Informed Residents

An informed resident is defined as an individual or group that has made at least one single visit to the project website, or interacted with the project through social media.

Residents were informed through:

- **5,916** Website Page Views
- **33,496** eNews Interactions
- **113,240** Social Media Interactions*
  *clicks, reactions, comments, and shares

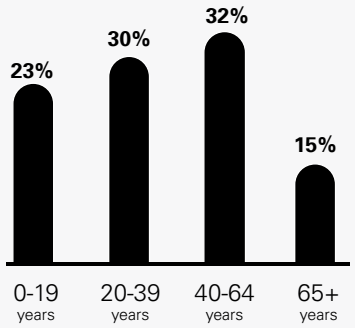
Who We Reached

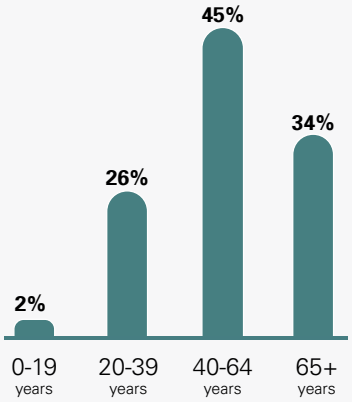
Our goal is to ensure we hear from a balanced and diverse range of residents in Surrey. Below is a profile of the City of Surrey compared with a profile of who we reached in this survey. By understanding who we've reached, we can better understand who we have not yet heard from and who we may still need to reach out to.

Community Profile

Survey Respondents

Age





Tenure

30% Rent **70%** Own

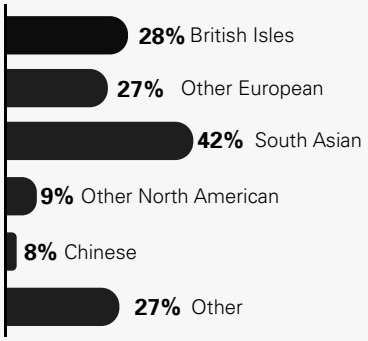
17% Rent **83%** Own

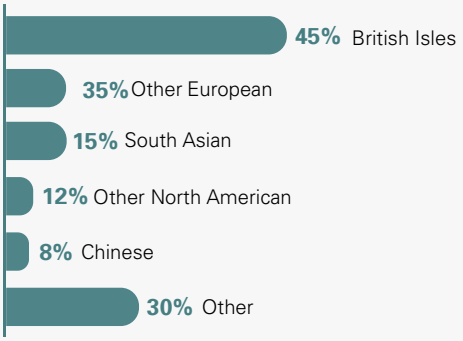
Income

Less than $30,000	**9%**
$30,000 to less than $59,999	**18%**
$60,000 to less than $99,999	**25%**
$100,000 to less than $149,999	**23%**
$150,000 or more	**26%**

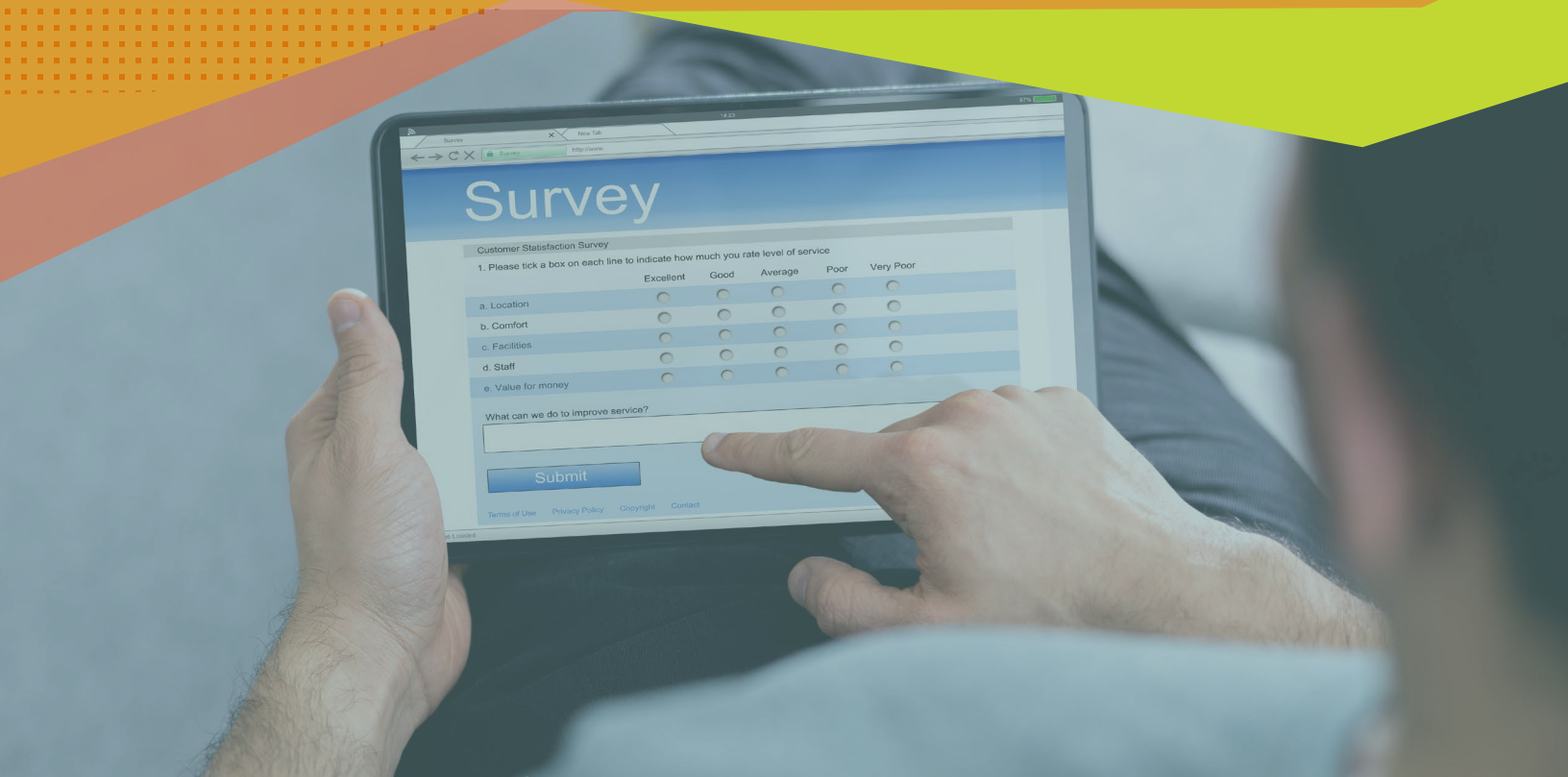
Less than $30,000	**7%**
$30,000 to less than $59,999	**18%**
$60,000 to less than $99,999	**26%**
$100,000 to less than $149,999	**24%**
$150,000 or more	**27%**

Ethnicity





A | Community Survey



What We Heard

Priority Directions

We identified 8 policy chapters listed below. Each chapter included high-level policy directions.

- Housing
- Economy
- Transportation
- Utility Infrastructure
- Natural Assets, Biodiversity & Green Infrastructure
- Community Infrastructure
- Climate, Natural Hazards & Emergency Preparedness
- Agriculture & Food Systems

1. We asked participants to select all policy chapters they wanted to provide feedback on. (2,467 responses)

Top four responses included:

80% said Housing

80% said Transportation

74% said Community Infrastructure

60% said Natural Assets, Biodiversity & Green Infrastructure

Other responses included:

59% said Economy

55% said Utility Infrastructure

53% said Agriculture & Food Systems

51% said Climate, Natural Hazards & Emergency Preparedness

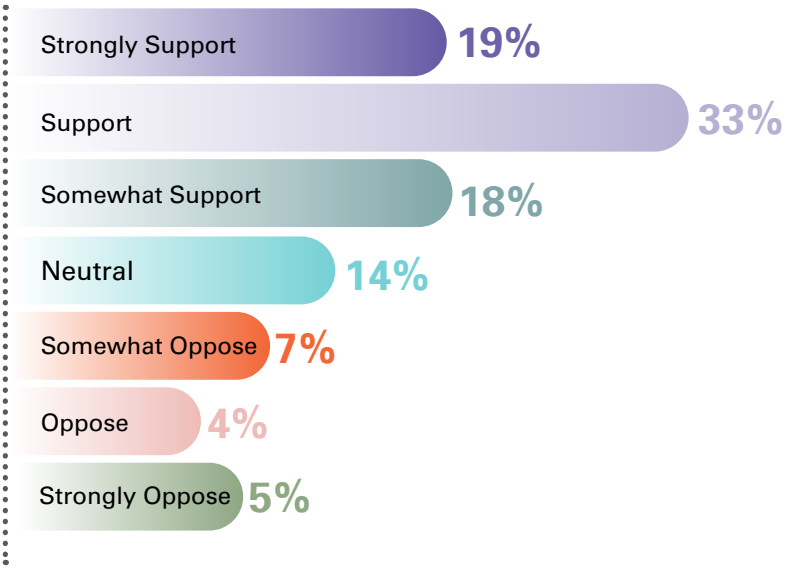
Chapter 1: Housing

Surrey is growing quickly, which is affecting housing availability and affordability, with more people renting than before. To plan for future needs, the Province requires cities to prepare Housing Needs Reports that call for more diverse, transit-accessible, and affordable housing options.

2a. We asked participants for their level of support for the proposed housing priority directions. (1,981 responses)

70%

Participants **Support** the Policy Directions



2b. For those who said, "support", we asked what makes them feel this way. (674 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Need for affordable housing options and increase in the housing supply.
- Support for greater diversity of housing options including purpose-built rentals and co-op housing.
- Support for more mixed-use developments.
- Suggestion for streamlined development process.

2c. For those who said, "oppose", we asked how we can improve on these policy directions. (226 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Concerns about crime & congestion.
- Suggestion to preserve green spaces & farmland.
- Need for infrastructure, services and amenities to support growing population.
- Suggestion to preserve community character.

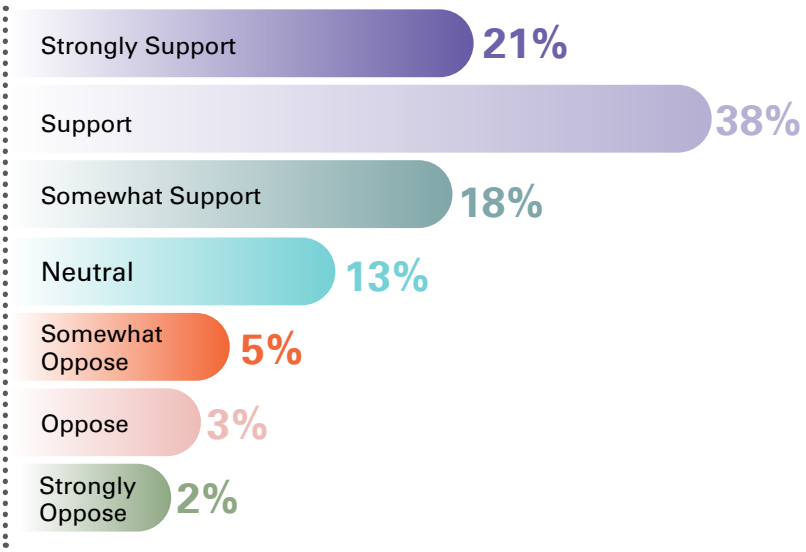
Chapter 2: Economy

Surrey is growing fast and needs to plan for jobs to support its economy. It has a mix of employment lands and is home to major institutions like SFU, KPU, and soon UBC.

3a. We asked participants for their level of support for the proposed economy priority directions. (1,374 responses)

77%

Participants **Support** the Policy Directions



3b. For those who said, "support", we asked what makes them feel this way. (438 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Emphasis on local job creation, businesses & employment opportunities.
- Desire for more local entertainment, recreation & cultural tourism destinations.
- Support for industrial activities & development.
- Support for community hubs and improved walkability.

3c. For those who said, "oppose", we asked how we can improve on these policy directions. (108 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Concerns about agricultural lands and green spaces.
- Suggestion to strengthen local economic resilience strategies.
- Suggestions to ensure inclusive and equitable growth.
- Concerns around vacant office space. Suggestion to rethink office space based on existing demands.

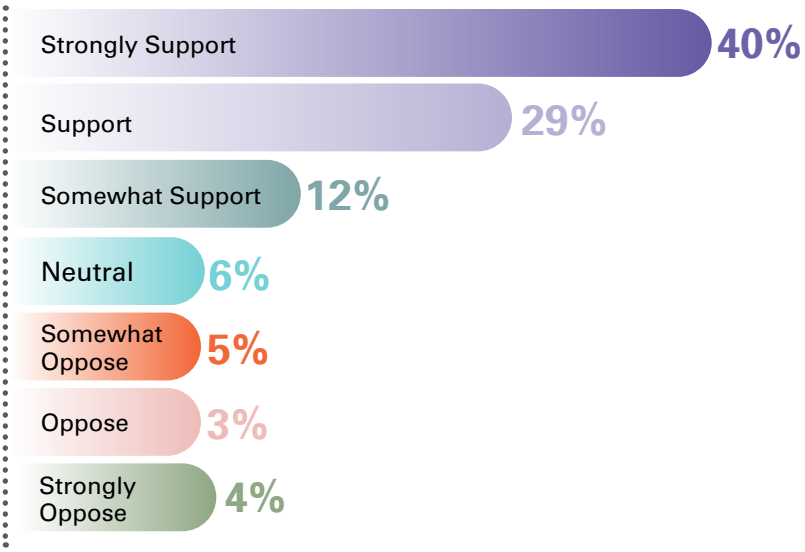
Chapter 3: Transportation

As Surrey grows, it needs better transit and more sustainable ways to get around. Improving transit access, building complete communities, and expanding bike lanes and sidewalks will help reduce emissions and provide sustainable ways to travel.

4a. We asked participants for their level of support for the proposed transportation priority directions. (1,842 responses)

81%

Participants **Support** the Policy Directions



4b. For those who said, "support", we asked what makes them feel this way. (834 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Support for better cycling & mobility infrastructure to improve safety, convenience & connectivity.
- Support for improved public transit.
- Support for improved traffic flow & commute times.
- Support for 15-minute neighbourhood.

4c. For those who said, "oppose", we asked how we can improve on these policy directions. (181 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Need for improved public transit e.g. dedicated bus lanes, service frequency, capacity etc.
- Concerns around increased dependency on cars.
- Concerns about safety, accessibility & crime on transit.
- Suggestion for weather protection while walking and cycling.

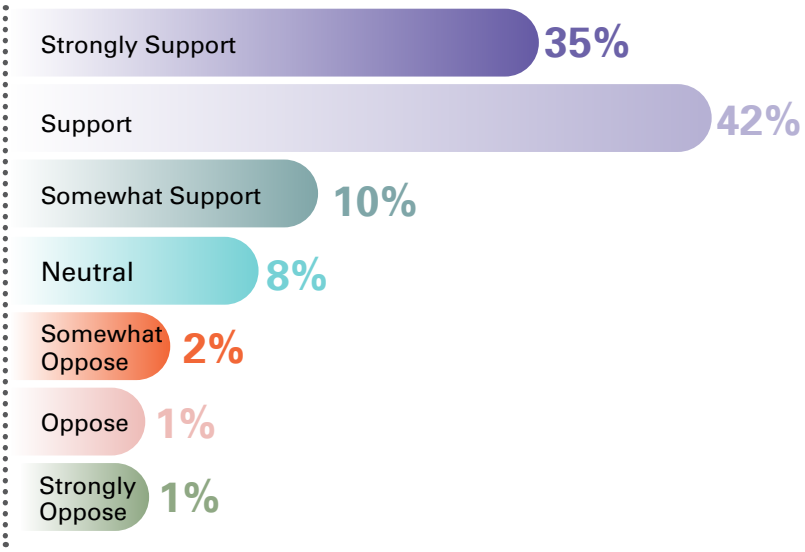
Chapter 4: Utility Infrastructure

Planning for growth needs reliable water, sewer, and drainage. Surrey will adapt services, work with other governments, and protect the environment.

5a. We asked participants for their level of support for the proposed utility infrastructure priority directions. (1,250 responses)

87%

Participants **Support** the Policy Directions



5b. For those who said, "support", we asked what makes them feel this way. (391 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Support for utility infrastructure improvements.
- Water, sewer and drainage are essential for community growth.
- Support for energy efficiency & conservation.
- Support for environmental protection & increased sustainability.

5c. For those who said, "oppose", we asked how we can improve on these policy directions. (46 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Drainage, flooding and the need for stormwater management upgrades.
- Suggestion for energy efficient and renewable energy sources.
- Emphasis on climate change and environmental protection.
- Concerns about water services and cleanliness.

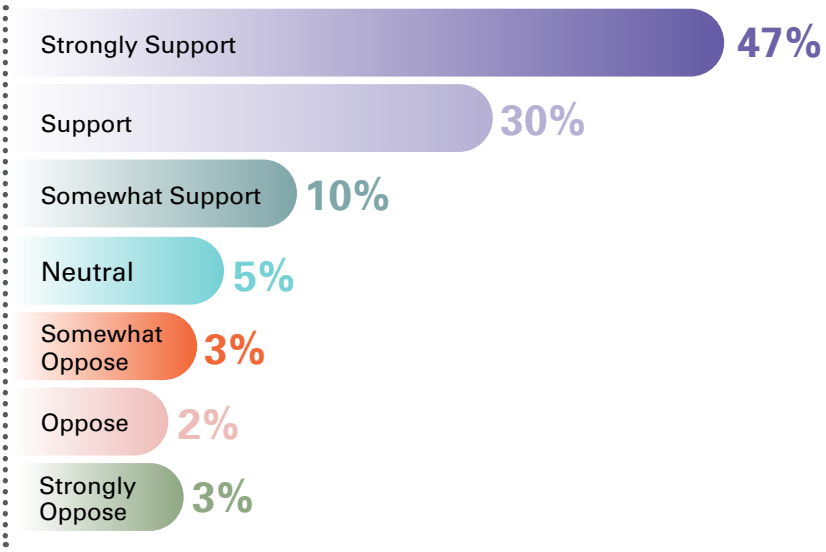
Chapter 5: Natural Assets, Biodiversity & Green Infrastructure

Surrey's natural assets like trees, rivers, and green spaces support wildlife, reduce pollution, and help fight climate change. Protecting these areas, including the goal to sustain 30% tree canopy, is key to balancing growth with long-term environmental resilience.

6a. We asked participants for their level of support for the proposed natural assets, biodiversity & green infrastructure priority directions. (1,356 responses)

87%

Participants **Support** the Policy Directions



6b. For those who said, "support", we asked what makes them feel this way. (586 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Preservation of trees and green space.
- Suggestions to expand green space/parks to support growing population.
- Importance of nature to city, livability, health & well-being of residents.
- Emphasis on biodiversity protection.

6c. For those who said, "oppose", we asked how we can improve on these policy directions. (85 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Need for more biodiversity, ecosystem and farmland preservation.
- Emphasis on more action on climate change and resilient policies.
- Suggestion for more tree canopy protection policies.

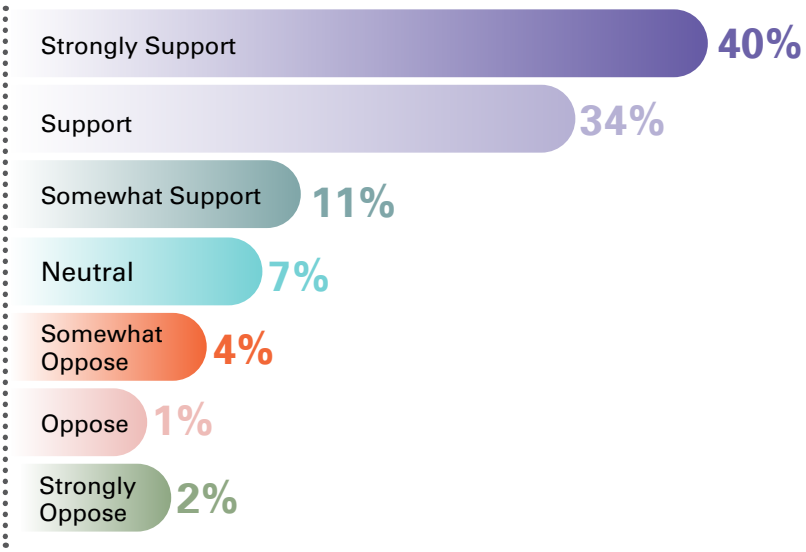
Chapter 6: Community Infrastructure

Community infrastructure like parks, libraries, and recreation centres supports residents' wellbeing and connection. As Surrey grows, so must these vital spaces to meet increasing needs.

7a. We asked participants for their level of support for the proposed community infrastructure priority directions. (1,657 responses)

85%

Participants **Support** the Policy Directions



7b. For those who said, "support", we asked what makes them feel this way. (674 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Need for more community centres and recreation facilities.
- Suggestions to invest in healthcare infrastructure e,g, hospitals, medical centres etc.
- Suggestion to invest in schools and institutions to support growing population.
- Suggestions for more parks, dog parks, natural areas and green spaces.

7c. For those who said, "oppose", we asked how we can improve on these policy directions. (98 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Emphasis on non-profit space, cultural and heritage programs.
- Suggestions to provide funding for developing adequate community infrastructure.
- Suggestions to improve childcare and youth supportive infrastructure such as after school programs, mental health amenities etc.

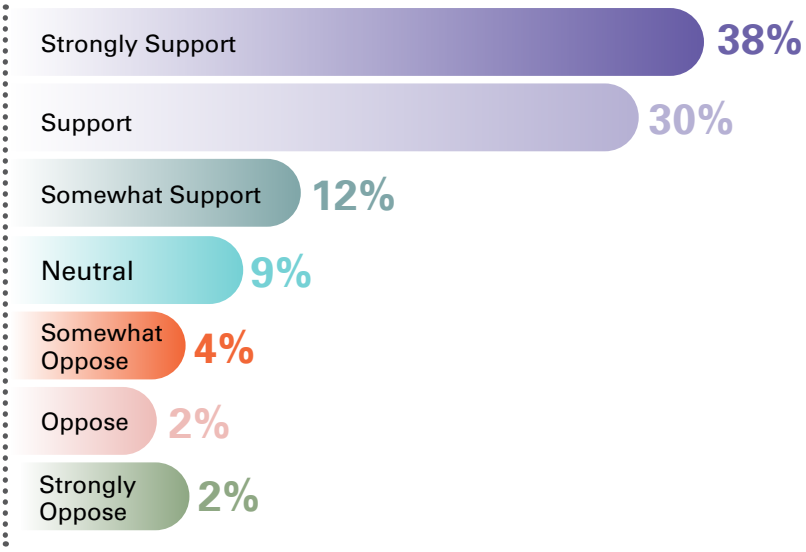
Chapter 7: Climate, Natural Hazards & Emergency Preparedness

Global warming leads to rising seas, heat waves, wildfires, and stronger storms. Surrey's OCP policies aim to reach net-zero emissions by 2050 and align with other plans, new provincial laws, and local hazard studies.

8a. We asked participants for their level of support for the proposed climate, natural hazards & emergency preparedness priority directions. (1,142 responses)

80%

Participants **Support** the Policy Directions



8b. For those who said, "support", we asked what makes them feel this way. (344 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Support for zero-carbon transportation & infrastructure e.g. EV charging, cycling and walking.
- Support for community involvement and greater awareness for emergency preparedness and climate change.
- Suggestion to enhance building energy efficiency.
- Desire for more connectedness and improved sustainability.

8c. For those who said, "oppose", we asked how we can improve on these policy directions. (99 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Concerns about cost effective electric and energy efficient methods.
- Preference for natural gas and using traditional energy sources.

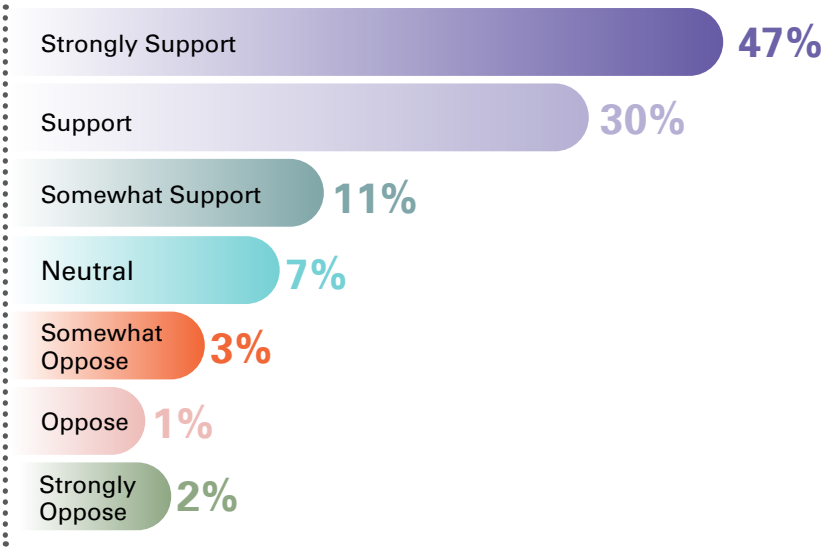
Chapter 8: Agriculture & Food Systems

About one-third of Surrey's land is in the Agricultural Land Reserve, protected for growing local food. Surrey farms support over 3,300 jobs. The OCP aims to protect farmland, expand local food access, and support a strong, sustainable agriculture sector.

9a. We asked participants for their level of support for the proposed agriculture & food systems priority directions. (1,186 responses)

88%

Participants **Support** the Policy Directions



9b. For those who said, "support", we asked what makes them feel this way. (538 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Support for protecting Agricultural Land Reserve.
- Suggestions to increase food security and use of high-tech, innovative farming, vertical farming and greenhouses.
- Support for local farmers and farm markets.
- Emphasis on urban agriculture and access to community gardens.

9c. For those who said, "oppose", we asked how we can improve on these policy directions. (52 responses)

Key themes that emerged:

- Concerns around ALR land protection and expansion.
- Ensuring greater food security and promote local farmers and produce.

B | In-Person Engagement

In-Person Engagement Participation

Between March and July 2025, there were 10 in-person engagement events in 10 locations across Surrey that comprises of:

- 4 OCP Pizza Parties
- 4 Seldom Heard Engagement events
- 1 Pop-up event and
- A presentation for the 55+ Housing Forum.

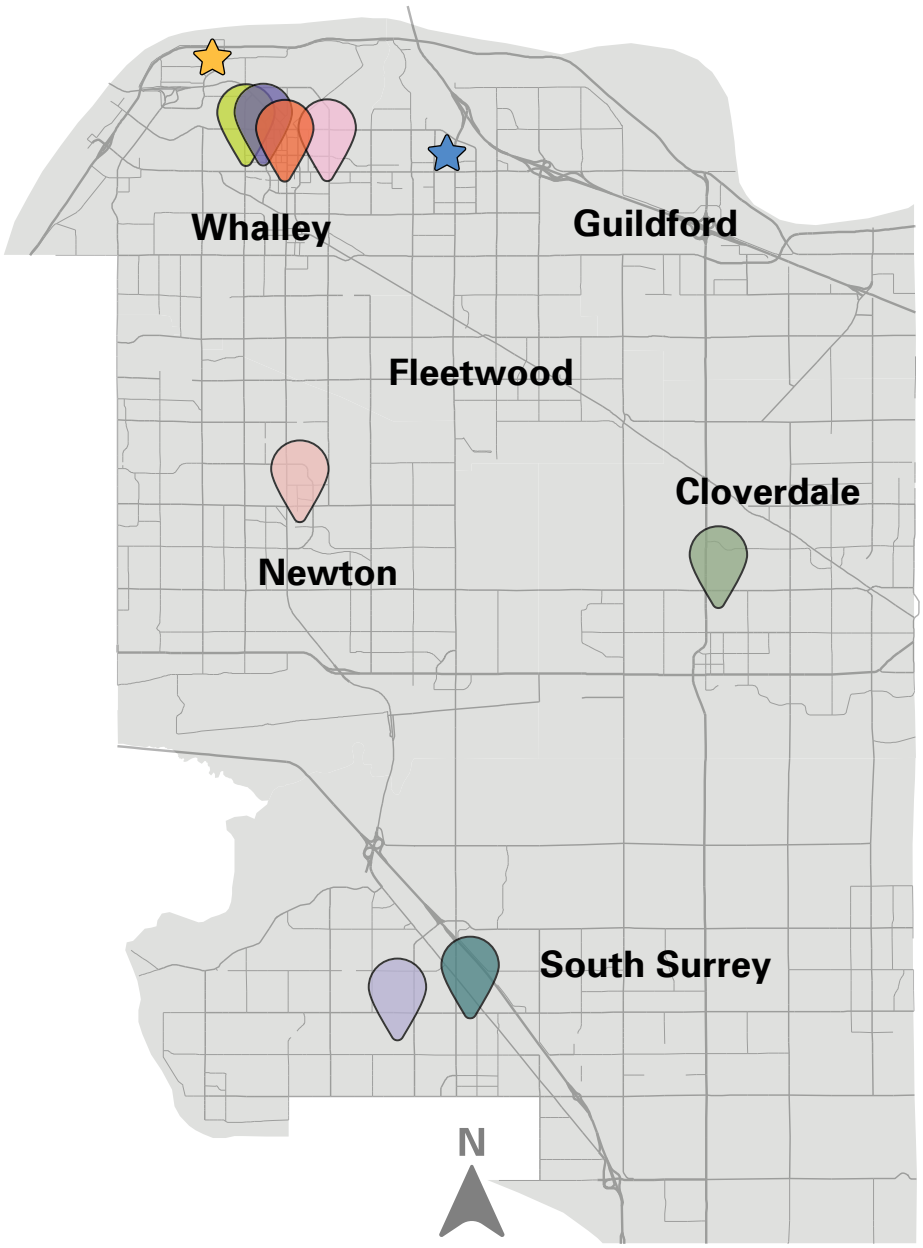
Along the way, there were:

50+ Pizzas Eaten

100+ Samosas Nibbled

400+ Drinks Sipped

30+ OCP Workbooks Completed



One Plan, Many Voices

Throughout Phase 3 engagement, we actively connected with diverse and inclusive communities to gather meaningful feedback. Providing translated materials, culturally appropriate food, and support from bilingual staff fostered a respectful space for open dialogue. This inclusive approach ensures a broader range of voices are helping to shape Surrey's OCP.

55+ Seniors Forum

- Guildford Recreation Centre, Guildford

Pop-Up

- Bridgeview Elementary School, Whalley

OCP Pizza Parties

- South Surrey Recreation & Arts Centre, South Surrey
- Cloverdale Recreation Centre, Cloverdale
- Surrey Library City Centre Branch, Whalley
- Newton Seniors Centre, Newton

Seldom Heard Engagement

- UNITI, South Surrey
- BC ACORN, Surrey City Hall, Whalley
- Solid State Community Industries, Whalley
- Surrey LIP, Library City Centre Branch, Whalley

OCP Pizza Parties

As part of the Official Community Plan (OCP) update, we held a series of "OCP Pizza Parties" at four locations across Surrey. These locations were:

- Cloverdale Recreation Centre
- South Surrey Recreation Centre
- Library City Centre Branch
- Newton Seniors Centre

Each event began with a short presentation, followed by guided roundtable discussions supported by staff and subject matter experts on topics like housing, climate, and transportation etc.

The final pizza Party focused on inclusion by offering bilingual engagement in English and Punjabi. This helped reduce language barriers and encouraged participation from underrepresented communities.

Key themes that emerged during the conversations were:

Housing

Emphasis on maintaining neighbourhood identity while meeting the housing demand.

Explore public subsidies and innovative solutions to create more affordable housing options.

Address housing needs for vulnerable groups and seniors and preventing displacement.

Economy

Desire for affordable spaces and funding support for small and local businesses.

Desire for more shops, services, and entertainment options through mixed-use developments while supporting local employment.

Enhance connections to industrial areas by improving transit access, and truck-friendly street design to support jobs and goods movement.

Transportation

Increase transit frequency, capacity, and service hours.

Enhance safety by protecting bike lanes and improving lighting.

Address traffic congestion and parking concerns.

Natural Assets, Biodiversity & Green Infrastructure

Support for diverse tree planting green roofs, and community gardens.

Recognition of importance of natural systems in community health, livability and biodiversity.

Climate, Natural Hazards & Emergency Preparedness

Support for mitigating natural hazards to better prepare for climate impacts and extreme events.

Desire for enhanced drainage systems in flood-prone areas.

Support for upgrading green infrastructure.

Community Infrastructure

Support for more parks, recreation facilities, and community spaces to accommodate population growth and meet diverse needs.

Suggestion to build a stronger sense of community through enhanced public realm and inclusive spaces.

Desire for accessible amenities.

Utility Infrastructure

Suggestions to upgrade and expand utility infrastructure to meet the growing demand.

Suggestions to explore resilient infrastructure design to address climate change.

Suggestions to be proactive with the planning process to match increased development.

Agriculture & Food Systms

Support for expanding urban food production and building connections through food-related programs.

Desire for stronger links between farmers and residents, including platforms to connect producers with consumers.

Opportunities to support diverse agricultural activities, agritourism, and job growth to promote local self-sufficiency.

55+ Housing Forum

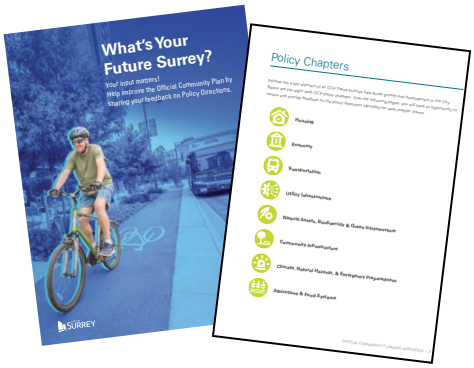
On March 15, 2025 City of Surrey hosted the 55+ Housing Forum. This event took place at Guildford Recreation Centre and provided valuable information on the variety of housing supports and services for older adults. A wide range of topics were covered, including programs that help older adults age in place, housing choices designed to meet the evolving needs of seniors, and support services that promote independence and well-being.

The forum covered topics that closely aligned with the OCP. We engaged with older adults to share information about the OCP update and gathered their feedback on key policy directions.

Pop-Up Engagement

We connected with children and their families at Bridgeview Elementary School during the school's 75th anniversary celebration through a pop-up engagement. Pop-Up is a short, informal outreach activity held in public spaces to meet people where they are.

We hosted a fun, interactive activity featuring a spinning wheel, where participants answered trivia questions and learned about the Official Community Plan (OCP) in exchange for small treats. This approach helped us share key information in an engaging and accessible way while reaching a broader audience.



As part of Phase 3 engagement, we invited Surrey residents to share their feedback by completing an Official Community Plan (OCP) workbook. The workbook was designed to make the engagement process more accessible and thoughtful, allowing participants to reflect on key directions and provide input at their own pace.

Seldom Heard Engagement

As part of the OCP update, the City partnered with community-based organizations to engage seldom-heard groups, ensuring that diverse perspectives, lived experiences, and community-specific priorities are reflected in the plan. Four targeted sessions were held in June 2025 with UNITI (partnership of 3 affiliated societies: Semiahmoo House Society, Peninsula Estates Housing Society and the Semiahmoo Foundation) ,British Columbia Association of Community Organizations for Reform Now (BC ACORN), Solid State, and the Surrey Local Immigration Partnership (Surrey LIP).

Each session focused on themes of housing, economy, transportation, and community infrastructure, while allowing participants to share creative and out-of-the-box ideas for Surrey's future. Key themes that emerged for these topics are mentioned below from each session.

UNITI - People with Disabilities

The engagement session with UNITI engaged Surrey residents with disabilities in Surrey, B.C. asking for their feedback on the OCP. Participants were members of UNITI's Semiahmoo Self Advocates group who are people with lived disability experience.

The key themes that emerged are:

- **Housing** - Suggestions to incentivize developers to adopt more accessible and safe design standards and to expand non-market housing and assisted living options for people with disabilities.
- **Economy** - Desire to see improvements in how employers support people with disabilities and provide opportunities for safe workplaces.
- **Transportation** - Emphasis on improving accessibility in streetscape and sidewalk design through features like tactile paving and clear signage, and ensuring pedestrian infrastructure can accommodate wheelchairs and other mobility devices.
- **Community Infrastructure** - Emphasis on improving accessibility in commercial, cultural, and recreation facilities and fostering a sense of belonging through design and public art.

Participants suggested increasing pedestrian crossing times near assisted living facilities and expanding access to free public washrooms.

BC ACORN - Renters and Housing Advocates

The engagement session with BC ACORN provided an opportunity to engage with primarily renters in the city. Participants came from diverse socio-economic backgrounds with an interest in housing and renter advocacy.

Key themes that emerged are:

- **Housing** - Participants called for more affordable and diverse housing types including co-ops, assisted living, large-family units, and transitional housing, along with stronger tenant protections against renovictions and improved building maintenance standards.
- **Economy** - Support for small, local businesses over large chains and more job opportunities for students, immigrants, and precarious workers, with better recognition of foreign credentials.
- **Transportation** - Desire for walkable neighbourhoods, improved cycling infrastructure, safer roads, and better transit connections.
- **Community Infrastructure** - Emphasis on recreation, health, and cultural amenities, better maintenance of public spaces, and inclusive park designs that serve seniors, families, and people experiencing homelessness.

Participants suggested creating a "live in Surrey, work in Surrey" talent recruitment strategy and designing large-family or intergenerational housing with suites for elderly residents.

Solid State - Young People of Colour

The engagement session with Solid State engaged young people of colour in the city. asking for their feedback on the OCP. Participants include representatives from Solid State's various community service or entrepreneurial cohorts.

Key themes that emerged are:

- **Housing** - Participants expressed a need for higher quality and more varied housing including culturally appropriate designs, larger family units, co-op models, and student housing, while raising concerns about affordability, unsafe rental conditions, and displacement.
- **Economy** - Participants showed interest in cultural tourism and beautification projects and wanted more job pathways for youth, immigrants, and recent graduates, including internships, co-ops, and small business support.
- **Transportation** - Desire for improved safety at night and around transit hubs, expanding sidewalks, street lighting, bus shelters, and providing more accessible transit options.
- **Community Infrastructure** - Suggestion for free or low-cost social spaces, more art and green spaces, better healthcare access, improved library services, and more capacity in recreation programs.

Participants proposed creating stronger employment "pipelines" for local youth and recent graduates, and advocating for safer working conditions.

Surrey Local Immigration Partnership (Surrey LIP) - Immigrants and Newcomers

The engagement session with Surrey LIP engaged immigrants and newcomers to the city, asking for their feedback on the OCP. The session included participants from Surrey LIP's Surrey Youth Newcomer Council, Immigrant Advisory Round Table and DIVERSECity's seniors network. Interpretation was provided in English, Punjabi, and Hindi.

Key themes that emerged are:

- **Housing** - Support for housing that meets diverse household needs such as large families, seniors, and multi-generational living, along with more affordable student and non-market housing located near amenities and transit.
- **Economy** - Suggestion to reduce barriers for newcomers to start businesses, expanding local job opportunities, and improving coordination among employment service providers.
- **Transportation** - Preference for compact, walkable neighbourhoods with everyday needs close to home, safer walking and cycling routes, better bus frequency, and improved transit connections within Surrey.
- **Community Infrastructure** - Desire for more recreation, cultural, and nightlife spaces, additional libraries and parks, child-minding services at recreation centres, and more healthcare facilities including specialized care for newcomers and families.

Participants suggested attracting employers with entry-level jobs to locate in Surrey and encouraging small-scale commercial uses such as pop-up markets and mobile shops in residential areas.

Next Steps

The feedback collected during Phase 3 will help shape the draft OCP policies. It will help ensure the final plan reflects community values and needs. The updated OCP is expected to be completed by the end of 2025.

Learn More

- Visit surrey.ca/planning for general information on the Official Community Plan.